THE LA'S
Lost La's 1986-1987: Callin' All
Viper (CD 008)

Comprised of fascinating early takes and a portion of an invigorating live set, The La's *Callin' All* is perhaps the quintessential post-Beatles record by a group from Liverpool.

Completely different from the bootleg of the same name, this *Callin' All* begins with eight four-track recordings, five of which would eventually find their way onto The La's' eponymous album in markedly different versions. Before he became a pop recluse, The

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La's' songwriter Lee Mavers insisted that this was how the band were meant to sound, and if one can get past the distinctly uncommercial production techniques — or their absence — hearing The La's at this early stage is rather like finding a new art form subsumed within another wholly more typical.

This is pop music at its essence, undiluted and absolutely pure. "Tears In The Rain," a rehearsal run-through that breaks off abruptly, approaches a kind of skiffle poetics, a hang-on-the-box rhythm enmeshed with a lyric — part "Remember (Walkin' In The Sand)," part Gerry Marsden. But the final four-track recording, "Callin' All," is the timeless offering, a lo-fi blend of power and portent, suggestion and revelation, with Mavers in the unlikely role of soothsayer. The song builds to a number of successive climaxes, each sustained and leading off toward the next, with Mavers' vocal not only uncomfortably detached, but also almost possessively insistent. "The world will fall/This is all we came here for," he sings. "I hear the ever distant 'calling all.'" Mavers would not have the band record the song for their only album.

As with the four-track recordings, the live set, captured in May '87 at The Picket in Liverpool, is vital work. The energy is rampant, delirious even, right from the start, with a bashing version of "Come In Come Out." Without a proper stage, The La's played on a few school dinner tables pushed together. I would maintain that these six songs, at this particular performance, represent one of the dozen or so greatest live rock 'n' roll documents. For a bit of history, there is one song that is given its first public airing. "New song," Mavers declares, and the band launches into "There She Goes," to which, if one would listen to it with headphones, would hear people dancing on tables.

— *Colin Fleming*